

SKELETON

THE SKELETON MAKES UP ALMOST ONE-FIFTH OF THE BODY'S WEIGHT. WITHOUT THIS INNER FRAMEWORK, ALL OTHER PARTS AND TISSUES WOULD COLLAPSE.

The average skeleton has 206 bones. There are natural variations: about one individual in 200 has an extra rib. Bone is an active tissue, and even though it is about 22 per cent water, it has an extremely strong yet lightweight and flexible structure. The skeleton has the advantage of being able to repair itself if damaged. It can also remodel its bones to thicken and strengthen them in areas of extra stress, as seen in some activities such as running and weight-lifting. The two major divisions of the skeleton are called the axial and appendicular skeletons. The axial skeleton consists of the skull, vertebral (spinal) column, ribs, and sternum. The appendicular skeleton includes the bones of the shoulder, arm, wrist, and hand, and the hips, legs, ankles, and feet. Of the 206 bones, 80 are in the axial skeleton, with 64 in the upper appendicular and 62 in the lower appendicular skeleton.

